

UNIVERSITY OF ESSEX

Second and Third Year Examinations 2002

SC301A: CURRENT DISPUTES IN SOCIOLOGY: SOCIOLOGICAL ANALYSIS III

Time allowed: 3 hours

Candidates must answer THREE questions. ONE from Section 1, ONE from Section 2, and the third from EITHER section.

The paper consists of 12 questions

Please do not leave your seat unless you are given permission by an invigilator

Do not communicate in any way with any other candidate in the examination room.

Do not open the question paper until told to do so.

All answers must be written in the answer book(s) provided and not on rough paper.

At the end of the examination, remain seated until your answer book(s) have been collected and you have been told you may leave.

Leave your scrap paper on the desk when you leave the examination room.

SECTION 1

1. In what ways, if any, does Foucault's work challenge Marxist understandings of power?
2. Critically assess the claim that gender is a matter of 'performance'.
3. What do you understand by ANY TWO the following concepts and which do you think is most useful for understanding contemporary western society ?
 - (a) globalisation
 - (b) the information society
 - (c) reflexive modernisation
4. What is a risk society? Do we live in one?
5. 'Do we live in post-modern culture'? Does it matter?
6. What is the potential of new technological developments for feminism as discussed by cyberfeminist theorists?

SECTION 2

7. 'There are fundamental similarities between the social and the natural sciences'. Which philosophical approach makes the best case for this position: Positivism or critical realism?
8. 'There is no point in teaching positivism to sociologists'. Discuss
9. What do you understand by
 - (a) instrumental rationality
 - (b) hermeneutics
 - (c) critical rationality
10. Is it possible to understand cultures very different from our own? Discuss in relation to either the Azande or the Innu.
11. Is post-modernist philosophy possible?
12. Critically assess the case for feminist standpoint epistemology.

END OF PAPER

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SECTION 1

1. What do you think are the main differences between Foucault's work and Marxism?
2. Critically assess the work of Judith Butler.
3. In what ways does post-modernism challenge the ideas about society associated with modernism?
4. What are the main contributions of Debord and Baudrillard to our understanding of contemporary culture?
5. 'The two central features of contemporary societies are the growth of information technology and globalisation'. Discuss.
6. Why should sociologists study cybernetics?
7. What do you understand by the following concepts:
 - (a) post-Fordism
 - (b) Reflexive modernisation
 - (c) Risk society

Are they helpful in understanding contemporary Western society?

SECTION 2

8. 'There is no point in teaching positivism to sociologists'. Discuss.
9. Critically assess the case for feminist standpoint epistemology.
10. What do you think are the main similarities and differences between the natural and social sciences?
11. Critically assess the work of either Habermas or Foucault.
12. 'If Peter Winch's thesis in *The Idea of a Social Science* is right, it is impossible to understand other cultures'. Discuss.
13. 'Post-modernism undermines all the usual arguments about the scientific status of sociology'. Discuss.

END OF PAPER